

GYMNASTICS



THERE ARE TWO MAIN BRANCHES of gymnastics – artistic and rhythmic. In artistic gymnastics, the gymnasts perform on fixed apparatus, such as bars and beams. In rhythmic gymnastics, they perform routines with apparatus such as hoops and balls. Other gymnastic sports include sports acrobatics and trampolining. In major artistic gymnastic competitions, the apparatus is set out on a large platform, or podium, and several events take place together. The competitors are awarded marks out of 10 by a panel of judges.

Men

There are six events in men's competitions. They are the floor, pommel horse, vault, rings, parallel bars, and high bar. Boys and men usually wear a singlet with shorts or white trousers. Men's gymnastics calls for strength as well as balance and dynamic movement.



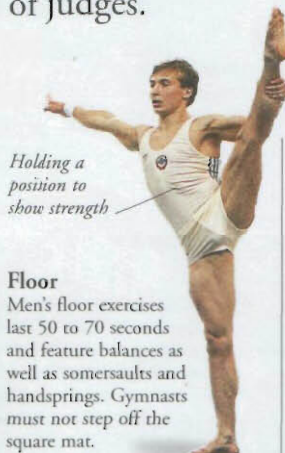
Pommel horse

The pommel horse needs arm and shoulder strength. The gymnast moves back and forth along the horse, swinging his legs up and over, supporting himself on his hands only.



Rings

More strength is needed on the rings than on any other apparatus. Gymnasts must hold some positions for two seconds and must not swing on the ropes.



Holding a position to show strength

Floor

Men's floor exercises last 50 to 70 seconds and feature balances as well as somersaults and handsprings. Gymnasts must not step off the square mat.



High bar

High bar routines contain continuous swinging moves. The gymnast circles around and around, with turns, twists, and changes of direction and grip.

Vault

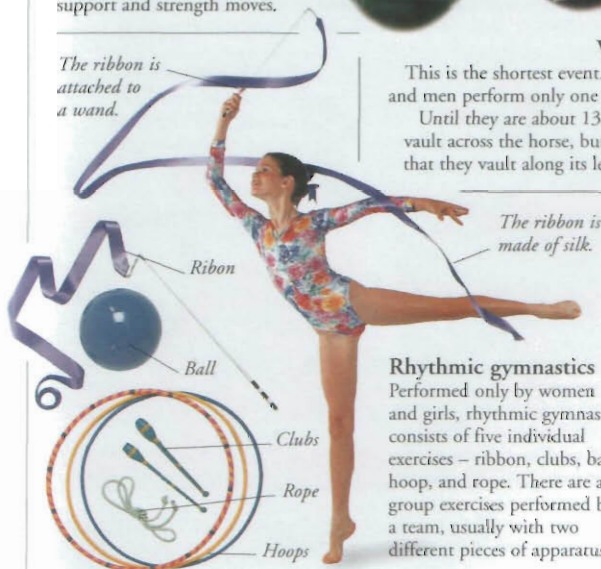
This is the shortest event. Boys and men perform only one vault. Until they are about 13, boys vault across the horse, but after that they vault along its length.



Parallel bars

The bars are a good all-round test for men. There is a wide choice of movements that a gymnast can perform, including swings and balances, and support and strength moves.

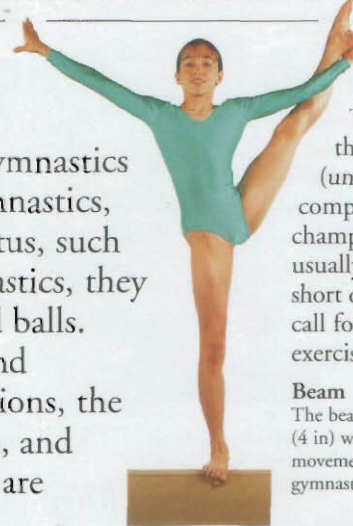
The ribbon is attached to a wand.



Rhythmic gymnastics

Performed only by women and girls, rhythmic gymnastics consists of five individual exercises – ribbon, clubs, ball, hoop, and rope. There are also group exercises performed by a team, usually with two different pieces of apparatus.

The ribbon is made of silk.

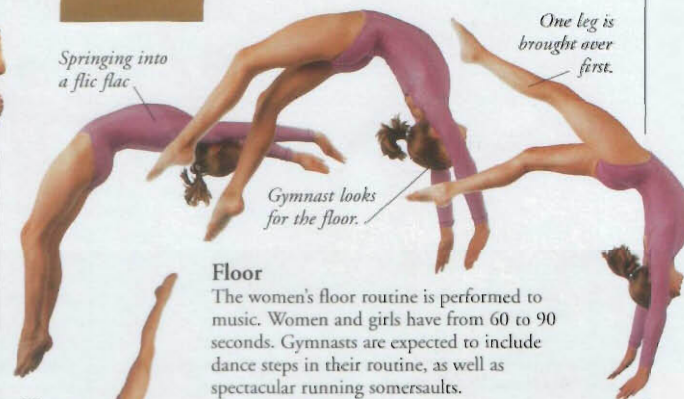


Women

There are four women's events – the floor, beam, asymmetric (uneven) bars, and vault. In competitions there is also an overall championship. Women and girls usually wear one-piece leotards with short or long sleeves. Women's exercises call for balance and agility, and floor exercises include elements of dance.

Beam

The beam is 5 m (16.4 ft) long and only 10 cm (4 in) wide. Gymnasts must perform deliberate movements and graceful balances. The leading gymnasts can perform somersaults and backflips.



Springing into a flic flac

One leg is brought over first.

Gymnast looks for the floor.

Floor

The women's floor routine is performed to music. Women and girls have from 60 to 90 seconds. Gymnasts are expected to include dance steps in their routine, as well as spectacular running somersaults.



Women vault across the width of the horse.



Asymmetric bars

This is possibly the most difficult of the women's apparatus. The gymnast must make full use of two bars 2.3 m (7.5 ft) and 1.5 m (5 ft) high, swinging and changing grip. The routine must have a flowing rhythm with no stops or hesitations.

Vault

Women and girls have two vaults in a competition, the better of the two marks counting. Different turns and somersaults are used, especially as the gymnast thrusts off the horse before landing neatly.

Nadia Comaneci

Romanian gymnast Nadia Comaneci (b.1962) became the first person to score a maximum 10 points in Olympic competition, at the age of 14. She scored seven 10s in the 1976 Montreal Olympics, winning the overall gold medal as well as separate golds for the bars and beam.



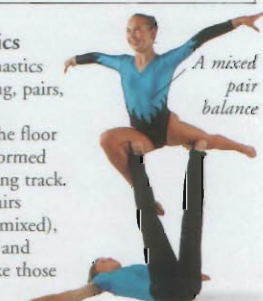
Trampolining

This is an excellent exercise routine for practising moves such as twists and somersaults, and it is also a sport in itself. There are solo competitions and synchronized pairs. Judges award marks for difficulty and how well a routine is performed.



Sports acrobatics

This type of gymnastics comprises tumbling, pairs, and group events. Tumbling is like the floor exercises, but performed on a straight, sprung track. The routines in pairs (men, women, or mixed), the trio (women), and fours (men) are like those of circus acrobats.



A mixed pair balance

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